steady herself inside the wobbly carriage.

“I don’t know.” There were no signs, only the train’s direction. The windows were ajar, and the air carried the screeching of metal wheels as they sped through the tunnel. The sisters held on to each other. They watched until they saw the enamel sign for *Gare de l’Est*. Obeying a nudge from their escort, they stepped off the carriage onto the platform.

“Stay close,” Léa whispered to Rose.

Rose gripped her sister’s arm as they took the stairs out of the Métro. This was the central transit station from France to Germany, so German officers patrolled the hallways, checking papers and searching bags. The officers’ rapid, deliberate movements, like gunfire, frightened Rose. She squeezed Léa’s hand, wondering if her sister felt the same. Léa turned and nodded—the first positive sign Rose had got from her sister since telling her she was going to Germany. Rose wanted to hug her and leaned forward, but Léa shook her head.

“No,” she said. “I haven’t forgiven you—” she smiled “—yet.”

As they made their way along a massive hall, Rose suddenly stopped and let go of Léa’s hand, stunned by what was in front of her. A painting hung above the enormous entrance leading to the platforms. It depicted a train carriage full of soldiers in uniform, and on the platform, distraught family members saying goodbye. Rose had never seen anything like it. She was struck by the muted colors, especially the blues shifting between a river’s darkness and the light of a summer sky. All the colors—green, pink, burgundy, brown, gray—shared a similar faintness as if the life had been washed out of every person and object.

But what drew her attention the most was the despondent expression on the faces of the women, children, and older men on the platform. Each bidding farewell as though they had no hope of seeing their loved ones again. Her gaze shifted to the far right corner of the painting, where a man held the tricolor French flag, partially obscured by his body.

She moved closer, squinting to read the painter’s signature: *Albert Herter, 1926*.

Léa yanked her arm. “Come on.”

In the distance, their German escort signaled impatiently with a wave of his hand, a severe look on his face. Glancing back at Herter’s painting, Rose felt a sudden foreboding.